A TREATISE

ON

THE USE OF THE TENSES IN HEBREW.

CHAPTER I.

Introduction.

1. The Hebrew language, in striking contrast to the classical languages, in which the development of the verb is so rich and varied, possesses only two of those modifications which are commonly termed 'tenses.' These tenses were formerly known by the familiar names of *past* and *future*, but inasmuch as the so-called *past* tense is continually used to describe events in the future, and the so-called *future* tense to describe events in the past, it is clear that these terms, adapted from languages cast in a totally different mould from the Hebrew and other Semitic tongues, are in the highest degree inappropriate and misleading. It will be better therefore to acquiesce in the names now generally employed by modern grammarians, and deduced from real and not fictitious or accidental characteristics of the two forms in question, and to call them by the terms *perfect* and *imperfect*[1] respectively.

2. For if we adopt these designations, we shall be continually reminded of the fundamental[2] character of the two

[1] These words are of course employed in their etymological meaning, as signifying *complete* and *incomplete:* they must not be limited to the special senses they have acquired in Greek and Latin grammar.

[2] It will appear hereafter that the term *imperfect* does not in strictness

'tenses,' and be thereby enabled to discern a rational ground for such phenomena as those alluded to, § 1, which, especially to persons who are perhaps more familiar with the languages of modern or classical times, appear when approached for the first time so inexplicable, so contradictory, not to say so absurd. In order properly to understand this fundamental character, we shall have to revert to a distinction which, though not unknown in other languages, has not, until recent years, obtained from Hebrew grammarians the recognition and prominence which it deserves. I allude to the distinction between *order* of time and *kind* of time. In the first place, a particular verbal form may exhibit a given action as prior or subsequent to some date otherwise fixed by the narrative: this is a difference in the order of time. But, secondly, an action may be contemplated, according to the fancy of the speaker, or according to the particular point which he desires to make prominent, either as *incipient*[1], or as *continuing*, or as *completed;* the speaker may wish to lay stress upon the moment at which it begins, or upon the period over which it extends, or upon the fact of its being finished and done: these are differences in the kind of time. Thus, for example, ἔπειθε and πείθει differ in the order or date, not in the kind of action specified: each alike expresses a continuous action, but the one throws it into the past, the other places it in the present. On the other hand, πεῖσαι and πείθειν, μὴ πείσῃς and μὴ πεῖθε differ in kind, not in date; in each the date is equally indeterminate, but the aorist indicates a momentary act, the

correspond to a primary but to a derived characteristic of the tense called by that name. Böttcher in his *Ausf. Lehrbuch der Hebr. Sprache*, it must be admitted with greater precision, gives to the imperfect the name of *fiens:* but inasmuch as what is *incipient* is also necessarily *imperfect*, the latter term may be fairly held to express a fundamental attribute of the tense. No sufficient ground therefore seems to exist for abandoning the now usual nomenclature in favour of the new and peculiar term preferred by Böttcher.

[1] Or, viewed on the side of its subject, as *egressive*.

present one that is continuous. Now in Hebrew the tenses mark only differences in the kind of time, not differences in the order of time: i. e. they do not in themselves determine the *date* at which an action takes place, they only indicate its *character* or *kind*—the three phases just mentioned, those namely of incipiency, continuance, and completion, being represented respectively by the imperfect, the participle, and the perfect [1].

3. Thus the 'tenses' in Hebrew, at least as regards what they do *not* express, are in their inmost nature fundamentally distinct from what is commonly known in other languages by the same name: indeed they might almost more fitly be called *moods* [2]. Certainly the difference between various kinds of time is clearly marked in Greek: but then it exists side by side with a full recognition and expression of the other difference, which in our eyes is of paramount importance (as regards *kind* of time we are mostly less sensitive), and which, nevertheless, Hebrew seems totally to disregard. And this is just the novelty with which we are here so struck, —the position occupied in the language by the one distinction that it appreciates, with the consequences which follow from it; and the fact that Hebrew, unlike Greek and most other languages, possesses no forms specifically appropriated to

[1] The distinction here drawn between the two relations, under which every action may present itself, is also insisted on, and further illustrated, by G. Curtius, in his *Elucidations of Greek Grammar* (translated by Abbott), pp. 203–212.

[2] This was the term employed formerly by Ewald; and Hitzig to the end spoke of the perfect as the *first mood*, and of the imperfect as the *second mood*. And in so far as each of the two forms in question seizes and gives expression to a particular phase of an action, 'mood,' suggestive as it is of the idea of *modification*, might seem the preferable term to adopt. Since, however, as we shall see, the Semitic languages developed for the imperfect special modal forms, which still exist in Hebrew, though not in the same perfection they exhibit in Arabic, and as it is convenient to have a separate name for the *genus*, of which these modal forms are the *species*, the more customary titles may be retained.

indicate date, but meets the want which this deficiency must have occasioned by a subtle and unique application of the two forms expressive of kind. Only, inasmuch as an action may of course be regarded under either of the three aspects named above, whether it belong to the past, the present, or the future—a writer may e. g. look upon a future event as so certain that he may prefer to speak of it in the perfect as though already *done*—an ambiguity will arise as to which of these periods it is to be referred to, an ambiguity which nothing but the context, and sometimes not even that, is able to remove. The tenses in Isa. 9, 5 are identical with those in Gen. 21, 1–3: it is only the context which tells us that in the one case a series of events in the future, in the other one in the past is being described. On the other hand, יָרַד Ex. 33, 9 refers to the past, 19, 11 to the future, although the tense does not vary; and יָסוּר שְׁמָה relating, 2 Ki. 4, 10, to the future, is used two verses previously to describe what happened in the past.

4. This peculiarity, however, is only an extension of what meets us, for instance, in Greek. We are sufficiently familiar with the distinction between ἐλάλησαν (as Acts 16, 32) and ἐλάλουν (as 19, 6): we are apt to forget that a similar distinction may appertain to events in the future as well as in the past. And, further, has not the *exact* date of both the actions quoted to be fixed from the context? Within what limits of time did the action ἐλάλησαν take place? and does ἐλάλουν signify 'they *used* to talk' (over a long period of time), or 'they *were* talking' (at the moment arrived at by the history, or when the writer came upon the scene), or 'they *began and continued* talking' (as consequent upon some occurrence previously described)? 'The imperfect,' it has been said, 'paints a scene:' true, but upon what part of the canvas? upon a part *determined by the whole picture.* And what has just been said we shall find to be pre-eminently true of the tenses as employed in Hebrew.

5. The tenses, then, in so far as they serve to fix the date of an action, have a relative not an absolute significance. It will, however, be evident that, since it is more usual, especially in prose, to regard a past event as completed, and a future event as uncompleted, the perfect will be commonly employed to describe the former, and the imperfect to describe the latter; but this distinction of usage is not maintained with sufficient uniformity to justify the retention of the old titles *past* and *future*, which will now clearly appear to express relations that are of only secondary importance, and only partially true. It is, on the other hand, of the utmost consequence to understand and bear constantly in mind the fundamental and primary facts stated above: (1) that the Hebrew verb notifies the character without fixing the date of an action, and (2) that, of its two forms with which we have here more particularly to deal, one is calculated to describe an action as *nascent* and so as imperfect; the other to describe it as *completed* and so as perfect. Upon these two facts the whole theory of the tenses has to be constructed; and the latter fact, at any rate, will be most readily remembered by the use of terms which at once recall to the mind the distinction involved in it.

6. The use of the Hebrew tenses will be better understood and more thoroughly appreciated if we keep in mind some of the peculiarities by which Hebrew style, especially the poetical and prophetical style, is characterized. One such peculiarity is the ease and rapidity with which a writer *changes his standpoint*, at one moment speaking of a scene as though still in the remote future, at another moment describing it as though present to his gaze. Another characteristic is a love for variety and vividness in expression: so soon as the pure prose style is deserted, the writer, no longer contenting himself with a series, for instance, of perfects, diversifies his language in a manner which mocks any effort to reproduce it in a Western tongue; seizing each individual detail he

invests it with a character of its own—you see it perhaps emerging into the light, perhaps standing there with clearly-cut outline before you—and presents his readers with a picture of surpassing brilliancy and life.

Obs. 1. With what has been said above, compare the opinion expressed, from a very independent point of view, by Bishop Patteson:—'I wish some of our good Hebrew scholars were sound Poly- and Melanesian scholars also. I believe it to be quite true that the *mode of thought* of a South Sea islander resembles very closely that of a Semitic man. . . . The Hebrew narrative viewed from the Melanesian *point of thought* is wonderfully graphic and lifelike. The English version is dull and lifeless in comparison' (*Life*, by Miss Yonge, 1874, ii. p. 475 f.). Again, 'An Englishman says, "When I get there, it will be night." But a Pacific islander says, "I am there, it is night." The one says, "Go on, it will soon be dark;" the other, "Go on, it has become already night." Any one sees that the one possesses the power of realizing the future as present or past; the other, *now*, whatever it may have been once, does not exercise such power' (p. 189). And so, 'the Hebrew's mind (and his speech) moved on with his thought, and was present with the whole range of ideas included in the thought' (p. 505). The time is 'not inherent in the *tense* at all' (p. 476).

Obs. 2. It does not fall within the scope of the present work to discuss at length the origin and structure of the two forms; though some indication of the principal opinions that have been held may not be out of place. The subject is discussed by Dietrich, *Abhandlungen zur Hebr. Grammatik* (1846), pp. 97 ff. (specially on the imperfect); Turner, *Studies Biblical and Oriental* (1876), pp. 338 ff.; Sayce, *The Tenses of the Assyrian Verb* (in the *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, Jan. 1877); and especially by Dr. Wright, *Comparative Grammar of the Semitic Languages* (1890), pp. 164 ff.; and on the other side (so far as the imperfect is concerned), by Philippi, *ZDMG.* xxix. 1875, pp. 171–174. In the perfect the resemblance of the third pers. masc. to an adjectival or participial form is evident and generally recognized: the oldest ending of the 3 sing. fem. *-at* is closely akin to that of the ordinary fem. of Arabic nouns: the 3 pl. *-ū*[1] is, perhaps, only modified from

[1] The form in יוּ, found thrice in the O. T. (Dt. 8, 3. 16. Isa. 26, 16), is hardly old: it appears, in fact, to be a *secondary* formation (see Nöldeke, *ZDMG.* 1884, p. 410 f.), found occasionally in Syriac and Mandaic, and more frequently in later dialects, as that of the Palest. Targums,

the usual pl. form *-ûna* by the omission of the final *-na* (which is dropped also in the st. c. of nouns). In the third person, therefore, the subject is not expressly represented, nor are there any *distinctively* verbal forms: in the second and first persons, on the contrary, the subject is regularly marked by a formative element appended to the base, the pronominal origin of which can hardly be mistaken (*-tā*, *-tem*, evidently akin to אַתָּה, אַתֶּם: and the old Semitic *-kū*, *-nā*, doubtless connected with the *-kī* and *-nū* of אָנֹכִי, אָנוּ, (אֲנַחְנוּ)[1].

In the imperfect, the first and second persons are formed pretty plainly by the aid of pronominal elements, though no longer affixed, as in the perfect, but prefixed, and not attached to a base bearing a concrete signification (participial), but to a base with one that is *abstract*[2], —mostly, indeed, agreeing in form with the infinitive. The origin of the third pers. is not so clear, and two divergent views have found their supporters. The old explanation, which derived the preformative י from הוּא, pronounced 'tolerably satisfactory' by Gesenius in his *Lehrgebäude* (1817), p. 274, and accepted by Ewald until 1844, must indeed for valid reasons (Dietrich, 122–126; Turner, 371 f.) be rejected, though voices are still occasionally heard in its favour (see J. Grill, *ZDMG.* xxvii. 434; F. E. König, *Lehrgebäude der Hebr. Spr.* i. (1881) pp. 156–9). The later theory of Ewald (*Lb.* § 191[a]) that the י is 'weakened from *l* or *n*' (the latter being the regular Syriac form) is likewise open to objection: but the view that a pronominal element still lies hidden in the prefix, alike in Syriac and in the other dialects, is capable of being

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the Jerus. Talm., the *Midrashim*, the *Evangeliarium Hierosolymitanum* (5th–6th cent. A.D.), published by Miniscalchi Erizzo; but mostly quite as an exceptional form. Examples: from Syriac, Acts 28, 2 ܡܬܐܘ (see also Hoffmann, § 53. 3; Merx, *Gramm. Syr.* p. 333; Nöldeke, *Syr. Gramm.* §§ 158 D. 176 E); from the Pal. Targs., the Jer. Targ. of Ex. 16, 1 אתון. Nu. 20, 21 סמון, הוון. 29 חמון, הימינון, בכון. Dt. 32, 16 אקנון. 30 ארגזון, *al.*, Ps. 53, 5 סערון. 54, 5 קמון. 69, 2 אעיקון. 76, 7 דמכון. 77, 17 רתיתון. 78, 58 אקנון. 106, 20 פרגון, *al.*; and esp. in verbs ל״א, as 48, 6. 58, 9 חמון; 60, 9. 62, 10 הוון; 106, 11 חפון; 107, 30 חרון, etc.; from Samaritan, Gen. 19, 2 ואמרון (also the imper. וביתון). 3 ואכלון. 32, 23. In the *Ev. Hier.* there are two instances (*ZDMG.* xxii. p. 491), ܢܫܬܘܢ and ܢܫܬܘܢ. Under the circumstances, the three isolated forms in the O. T. can hardly be original: had the form been in actual use in ancient Hebrew, it is difficult not to think that instances would have been more frequent.

[1] See more fully Dr. Wright's *Comp. Gr.* pp. 164 ff.

[2] A genuine Semitic construction: comp. below, § 189.

placed upon a more defensible basis; and it is accordingly asserted by Dillmann, *Aeth. Gramm.* § 101. 2, and, in particular, by Philippi, *ZDMG. l. c.*, who points, for example, to the traces of old demonstrative roots *ya* and *na* existing in the different Semitic languages[1], and whose arguments are well worthy of consideration. Many recent grammarians have, however, given their assent, more or less pronounced, to the powerful reasoning by which Dietrich, in the Essay referred to above, advocates the originally nominal character of the third person. The line of argument pursued by him may be stated very briefly as follows. Dietrich starts with the remark that it would only be natural to find in the imperfect the two peculiarities observed in the perfect, the presence in it, viz., of a *double mode* of flexion—the first and second persons being compounded with pronouns, the third being formed and declined on the analogy of a noun—and the fact that the ground-form of the tense, the third masc., is not distinguished by any special sign of the person: he next calls attention to the features in which the third imperfect, especially in Arabic, resembles and is treated as a noun—features recognized and noted by the native Arabic grammarians (Wright, *Arab. Gr.* i. § 95), and doubtless forming a strong argument in favour of the theory: in the third place, he collects (pp. 136–151), from Hebrew and the other dialects, numerous examples of the nominal form יִלְקוֹשׁ, יִצְהַר, יִרְיב, יְקוֹם, etc., which, though in some cases even identical with the tense-form, still cannot as a class be derived from it (on account of their varying vocalization, their appearance in Syriac, and for other reasons), but must be regarded as an independent though parallel formation. This form is in use to represent sensible qualities or attributes,—originally, it would seem, as purely mental conceptions, i. e. as abstract (cf. יִתְר, יִעַן), but in practice restricted mainly to the representation of the quality as manifested in some concrete object: hence, as a rule, it designates an object under a specially active or conspicuous attribute, being often employed adjectivally to denote a striking bodily peculiarity or defect, or to provide a name for some plant or animal from a characteristic feature[2].

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[1] As in אֲנִי = *'an + ya:* cf. Wright, *Comp. Gr.* p. 99.

[2] The *transition* of meaning indicated above is essential to Dietrich's own view of the parallelism between the noun and the tense; the imperfect, with him, denotes primarily an action or state, not (like the perfect) as objectively realized, but as subjectively *conceived*—as assumed, for example, by the speaker, or as desired or viewed by him as conditional or dependent: its concrete application, though predominant, is deduced and secondary.

Dietrich now advances, but with greater reserve (p. 155, *ohne mehr als die Stelle einer Muthmaassung in Anspruch zu nehmen*), a similar explanation for the third fem. As תקטל is not distinguished from יקטל by the usual mark of the feminine, the first step is to shew that cases exist in which the Semitic languages give expression to a difference of gender, not by the normal change of termination, but by having recourse to a different derivative (e. g. masc. *akbaru*, fem. *kubraʾ*). Next, he collects, as before, instances of the substantives created by prefixing ת, pointing out the close resemblance between the various groups of these and the groups formed with י, and indicating the reasons which forbid their being treated as themselves derivatives from the imperfect (pp. 139, 165–171), while at the same time they are plainly parallel to it. The characteristic of this class is to represent an action under the most abstract relation possible: it is thus strongly contrasted with the previous class exhibiting י, and is adapted, in accordance with the principle just established, to mark the opposite gender,—its appropriation for this purpose being probably facilitated by the resemblance of the prefix ת to the ordinary sign of the feminine (cf. Turner, p. 374; Sayce, p. 30; Stade, § 505). In a word, according to Dietrich, out of the double group of nouns, analogous in form, but contrasted in signification, one of uniform formation was selected from each—of course, at a remote period, when both forms were, so to say, more *fluid* than they subsequently remained—and set apart to mark the two opposite genders of the nascent tense. And, in conclusion, the Syriac imperfect in ܬ is shewn to be capable of an explanation in complete agreement with the same theory, being similarly related to a corresponding nominal form in ܬ, existing both in Syriac itself and also in Hebrew.

This hypothesis of the origin of the third pers. is accepted substantially by Böttcher, § 925 (the י not a mark of the person, but of the tense); Merx, p. 199 f.; Koch, *Der Semitische Infinitive* (1874), p. 7; Turner, p. 373 f.; Sayce, *l. c.*, pp. 23–27, 30–32; and Stade, *Lehrbuch der Hebr. Grammatik* (1878), § 478c. While agreeing on the whole, however, these scholars differ as to details: thus Böttcher expressly disconnects, § 927, the ת of the fem. from the nominal ת, § 547d, and Stade also considers that it is difficult. Mr. Turner, again, lays no stress on Dietrich's first, or abstract, stage; and Prof. Sayce appears disposed to identify unduly (pp. 29, 33) the form of the third pers. with the base of the first and second. Olshausen, *Lehrbuch* (1861), § 226c, regarded the explanation of the third pers. as 'still obscure;' Kautzsch, in the 25th ed. of Gesenius' Grammar (1889), § 47. 2, and Aug. Müller, in his *Schulgrammatik* (1878), § 171a, express themselves in similar terms, although the latter inclines towards Dietrich's view in the case of the masc.

(§ 174[a]). Dr. Wright, however (*Comp. Gr.* pp. 179, 182), thinks that the prefix *ya* must be of pronominal origin = 'one who,' though he is apparently dissatisfied with the parallels cited by Philippi, and admits that he cannot explain it etymologically. The ת of the fem. he supposes (p. 184) to be the same mark of the fem. gender which appears at the end of the oldest form of the 3 sing. fem. in the perfect.

The discovery of the origin of a grammatical form is of the highest value to the comparative philologist, or the student of primitive modes of thought; it does not of necessity throw fresh light directly upon the meaning borne by it in practice, particularly if the period of formation be long anterior to that in which the examples of its use actually occur. In the case before us, either view must be regarded at present as conjectural: the cognate languages do not exhibit the imperfect tense in a form so diverse from the Hebrew as to enable us to perceive, either immediately or by a conclusive inference, the elements of which it is composed; there are probable arguments in abundance, but no crucial fact appears to have been yet produced. The utmost that can be done is to appeal to analogy. Much has been said, for instance, on the originally *abstract* character of the third imperfect: and in favour of the assumption languages such as Turkish are cited, in which certainly the third pers. of the past tense appears to be an abstract substantive; still before we can build with safety upon the analogy, we ought to possess some practical acquaintance with the languages in question, both as regards their general character and (if possible) their history. Otherwise the comparison may be superficial or unreal. Again, in the particular form which the theory takes in Dietrich's hands, it should be remembered that it depends upon a coincidence,—upon the agreement between an assumed transition of meaning in the noun and an assumed derivation of significations in the tense. And in applying it to the purpose immediately before us, there is an additional difficulty in the fact that it postulates a *triple* structure for a single tense. The perfect is formed homogeneously throughout: the imperfect, on the contrary, presents one formation for the third masc., another for the third fem., a third for the other persons (for Philippi is certainly right in maintaining, against Koch, that these cannot be naturally explained as contracted from *ta-yaktul*, *a-yaktul*, etc.—the pronominal element being prefixed to the form of the third pers. *yaktul*): which of these three, now, is to be regarded as expressing the fundamental character of the tense? The second fem., not being a primary formation, may indeed be set aside: but with which of the other two are we to start in our exposition *à priori* of the meaning conveyed by it? Perhaps, however, it may be fair to assume that the third pers. masc. gave the *type* of the tense, to

which the other persons, though constructed out of different elements, were then made conformable, the external parallelism of form being symbolical of the internal unity of signification thereby secured to the entire tense. This being so, its representative power will be analogous to that of the corresponding nominal form: i. e. (if we confine ourselves to what is the predominant signification of the noun) it will depict an act or attribute, not as a quiescent fact, but as the manifestation of an energy residing in the subject, or as 'a stream evolving itself from its source:' the subject will be conceived as exerting itself in the production of an activity, the action as egressive (cf. Turner, pp. 376 f., 383-385). יראה, ישמח, there is the faculty of seeing, the capacity of joy, realizing itself in the subject; the processes of seeing, of rejoicing, are not represented to us as completed (as by the perf., 'in einem nach allen Seiten hin begränzten und erfasslichen Bilde,' Dietrich, p. 113), but as being actively manifested by the subject; in other words, he *sees*, *rejoices*. Here the alternative theory of the nominal origin of the third pers. is represented in its simplest form. Fortunately, however, the view thus obtained of the primary idea of the tense hardly differs materially from that which has been already expressed in these pages; for such terms as *incipient*, *nascent*, *progressive*, §§ 2, 21, 43 (understood in connexion with the context), do not convey an appreciably different conception from that which now occurs to me as fairly embodying the other opinion (at least as held by Mr. Turner), viz. *egressive*. As the latter makes prominent what after all is the fundamental fact, namely, the objective relation of the action to the subject which exhibits it, I have not scrupled to introduce it, together with a few other modifications, into the text of this and the third chapter.

It may be worth while to add that analogies exist in other languages for the substantival character of the verb, which must certainly be allowed in the case of the third pers. of the Semitic perf., and which is postulated by Dietrich's theory for the third pers. impf. There was doubtless a time when 'noun' and 'verb' were as yet indistinguishable (cf. Curtius, *Das Verbum der Griech. Sprache*, i. p. 13), and Schleicher has shewn in a lucid and valuable Essay, *Die Unterscheidung von Nomen und Verbum in der lautlichen Form* (extracted from the *Abhandlungen der phil.-hist. Classe der Kön.-Sachs. Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften*, iv. 1865), that the clearness and decision with which the Aryan family of speech has expressed the distinction of noun and verb, is far from being a general characteristic of other languages. In Indo-Germanic, 'words which have or had a case-suffix are nouns, those which have or had a personal suffix are verbs:' but the third pers. of the Semitic perf. at once reveals to us that the separation of the two parts of

speech is by no means here so complete. Semitic, in this respect, resembles rather, for instance, Finnish, in which (p. 530) *saa* being 'accipere,' and *saa-va* 'accipiens,' the third pl. pres. is *saa-va-t* 'accipiunt,' lit. 'accipientes:' or Samoyedic, where an adjective, and even a substantive, may be used and conjugated exactly as a verb (pp. 537, 539); and where the possessive suffixes to the noun and the personal suffixes in the verb bear the closest resemblance to each other (so also pp. 527, 535, 542); or Mexican (p. 568), where there are no 'true verbs' (cf. Steinthal, *Characteristik*, pp. 216–218),—the plural of the verb being formed in the same manner as that of the noun[1]. The agreement of the third pers. with a nominal form, and the absence from it of any personal sign is in fact, he remarks (p. 515), a phenomenon often meeting us in other languages[2], particularly where the verb is no verb in the Indo-Germanic sense of the word, but rather a noun: in such cases, the pronoun of the third pers. calls for no special designation, being understood of itself, and it is only the other persons which require to be separately indicated. Though we must not place Semitic on a level with the Polynesian Dayak (respecting which, see Steinthal, p. 165, or Sayce, *Principles of Comparative Philology*, p. 281, ed. 1), we may admit, with Dietrich (p. 136) and Turner (p. 366), no less than with Schleicher, that the distinction between noun and verb does not find in it, formally, the same clear expression as in the languages of our own Aryan family[3].

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[1] Schleicher's thesis, 'that no grammatical categories exist in the consciousness of the speaker which do not find formal expression in sound,' is doubtless enunciated in terms which are too general, and cases may readily be imagined in which it does not apply (see, above all, Bréal, *Sur les idées latentes du langage*, in his *Mélanges de Mythologie et de linguistique*, pp. 300 f., 308 ff., 312 ff.); but he is right in refusing as a rule to credit a people with a sense of grammatical relations which find no expression in their speech, and in protesting against the assumption—often unconsciously influencing us—according to which all languages are framed on the same model, expressing the same distinctions, and possessing the same resources, as those with which we happen to be ourselves familiar.

[2] Instances from Magyar (p. 527), and from the Mongolian Buriat (p. 546), in which 'the third perf., in form and signification alike, is a noun.'

[3] Comp. further, on the subject of the preceding note, J. Barth, *Die Nominalbildung in den Semitischen Sprachen* (1889–91), pp. 228, 279 f., 484 f.

CHAPTER II.

The Perfect alone.

N. B. Throughout the present volume, in every pointed word quoted without its proper accent, the tone is *always on the ultima* (milra'), *unless specially marked otherwise* by ֫. Attention to the position of the tone is of importance for a right understanding of the language; and the necessity of observing it cannot be too emphatically inculcated. By acquiring the habit of doing this regularly, the eye will become trained so as to notice it instinctively and without effort, and will be at once arrested by any deviation a word may present from the customary rule.

7. THE perfect tense, in accordance with its fundamental character, as stated § 2, is used—

(1) As equivalent to the Greek aorist, to denote an action completed and finished at a definite moment in the past, fixed by the narrative; as Gen. 1, 1. 3, 16 unto the woman אָמַר *he said.* 10, 8 יָלַד. 25, 30 קָרָא. 32, 11 *I passed over.* 49, 30 f. Ps. 18, 5. 6. 9. 30, 3. 32, 4 *was turned.*

Even though the action indicated by the verb should itself extend over a considerable period; as Ex. 1, 7 פָּרוּ. 12, 40. Nu. 9, 23. Dt. 2, 14. 1 Ki. 15, 2 three years מָלַךְ *he reigned.* Ps. 35, 13 f.; or even though it be repeated, as in 1 Sa. 18, 30[1].

8. (2) Like the Greek perfect, to denote an action completed in the past, but with the accessory idea of its conse-

[1] Whether in cases like these the pf. or impf. is employed, depends naturally upon the *animus loquentis:* if the speaker does not desire to lay any special stress on the frequency or continuance of an event, the simplest and most obvious way of designating it will be by the employment of the perfect.

quences continuing up to the time at which the words are uttered: it is thus employed to describe an action resulting in a *state*, which may be of longer or shorter duration, according to the context. Thus Gen. 4, 6 why נפלו *hath* thy face *fallen?* 32, 11 *I have become* (LXX γέγονα) two camps. Isa. 1, 4 *have forsaken* Yahweh. 5, 24b. Ps. 3, 7. 5, 11. 10, 11 הסתיר. 16, 6. 17, 5 בַּל נָמוֹטִי *have* not *tottered*. 11. 18, 37. 22, 2. 31, 15 *have trusted*.

Where the consequences of such an action continue into the present we may sometimes render by the present tense, although, if idiom permits it, it is better to preserve the perfect. Amos 5, 14 as *ye say*. Ps. 2, 1 why do the peoples rage? (*have raged*—an action which the context shews has not ceased at the moment of the poet's writing). 38, 3–9 *are* filled, *am* benumbed, etc. 88, 7–10. 14. 16–19. Isa. 21, 3 f. Job 19, 18–20.

Obs. It is of importance to keep the aoristic and perfect senses of this tense distinct, and also to ascertain upon every occasion which of the two is meant, whether, in other words, the action or state described by the tense is one which has ceased, or one which still continues. There is frequently some difficulty upon this point, especially in the Psalms: and unless care be taken in translation, the sense of a passage may be much obscured. For instance, Ps. 31, 7 f. (Heb. 8 f.) in the English Versions, is only intelligible by the side of *v.* 10, if the perfects are explained according to § 14. This is possible, but it is more natural to suppose that the two cohortatives express a wish or prayer rather than an intention, and that ידעת, ראית are aoristic, relating to a former condition of things now come to an end. The English 'thou hast considered' in no way suggests the possibility of such a termination: and the sense of the Hebrew is only properly represented by 'sawest . . . tookest notice of,' etc. (so Cheyne). Similarly, 32, 4 (*was*, not *is;* the context shews that the period of depression is past); but 35, 15 f. 21 ('rejoice, gather,' etc.: the petition *v.* 17 is an indication that the persecution described does not belong wholly to the past): 39, 3 *was* dumb, but *v.* 10 *am* dumb.

The same doublesidedness of the perfect will explain Lam. 3, 55–58: the pff. in these verses are aoristic, describing a state of things *anterior* as well to *vv.* 52–54 as to *vv.* 59–61 (ראיתה *v.* 59 exactly as Ps. 10, 14.

35, 22: the change from *v.* 54 to *v.* 55 is not more abrupt or unprepared than the very similar one between Job 30, 31 and 31, 1). In Lam. 4, 7 (*were*). 8 (*is*), the two senses occur side by side.

9. (3) In cases where in English the perfect *has* is used idiomatically to describe an action occurring in the past at a moment which the speaker is not able or not desirous to specify more closely; as 1 Sa. 12, 3 whose ox לָקַחְתִּי *have I taken?* [or *did I* (ever) *take?*]. 4[1]. Ps. 3, 8 thou hast smitten (on some previous occasion). 4, 2. 7, 4. 21, 3. 37, 35[2]. 44, 2. Pr. 21, 22 (cf. Qoh. 9, 14 f.). Job 4, 3. 9, 4. 30, 25. 31, 5 etc. 33. 34, 31. 37, 20 did a man ever say (=intend *or* command) that he should be annihilated? Jer. 2, 11[a].

In these cases, the limits of time within which the action must lie are obvious from the context: passages like Gen. 4, 1 קָנִיתִי. 10 מֶה עָשִׂיתָ *what hast thou done* (a few moments ago)? or *what didst thou do?* (just now; but the former is the English idiom). 32, 27. 31. 41, 28. Ex. 2, 18. Nu. 22, 34. Ps. 2, 7[c]. 30, 4. 48, 4 נוֹדַע hath made himself known; and the common phrase כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה Ex. 4, 22 etc. lead us on to the next usage.

10. (4) Here the perfect is employed to describe the immediate past, being generally best translated by the present; as Gen. 14, 22 הֲרִמֹתִי *I lift up* (have this moment, as I speak, lifted[3]) my hand to heaven. 1 Sa. 17, 10 חֵרַפְתִּי I reproach. 2 Sa. 16, 4 I bow myself down. 17, 11 I advise. 19, 30 I say. 1 Ki. 1, 35 ואתו צויתי and him do I appoint to be prince over Israel, etc. 2 Chr. 2, 12 (in a letter[4]) I send.

11. (5) Closely allied to (3) is the use of the perfect with such words as יָדַעְתִּי Gen. 4, 9. 21, 26 *I have* not *known*=*I*

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[1] Cf. Thucyd. 5, 103 *οὐ καθεῖλεν, never ruined.*

[2] Comp. Sophocles, Ajax 1142 (aorist), 1150 (perfect).

[3] Compare in Greek the so-called 'aorist of immediate past,' so common in the tragedians, e. g. Aesch. Choeph. 423. Soph. El. 668 *ἐδεξάμην* (*I welcome*) *τὸ ῥηθέν.* 677 etc.

[4] Cf. 2 Cor. 8, 18. Acts 23, 30.

do not *know;* זָכַרְנוּ Nu. 11, 5 *we remember;* כַּאֲשֶׁר אָהַב Gen. 27, 9 as *he loveth.* In verbs like these, expressive of a state or condition, whether physical or mental, which, though it may have been attained at some previous time, nevertheless continues to exist up to the moment of speaking, the emphasis rests so often upon the latter point, that the English *present* most adequately represents the force of the original perfect.

To the verbs already cited may be added, as belonging to the same class, the following, which are selected from the list given by Böttcher, *Ausf. Lehrbuch*, § 948: by this grammarian they are not inaptly termed *verba stativa* or 'statives,' אָמְלַל *to languish;* בטח *to trust* Ps. 26, 2 etc.; גבה *to be high* Isa. 55, 9; גָּדַל *to be great* Ps. 92, 6; דָּמָה *to be like* Ps. 144, 4; זקן *to be old* Ruth 1, 12; חָסָה *to take refuge* Ps. 7, 2 etc.; טהר *to be clean* Pr. 20, 9; יָכֹל *to be able* Ps. 40, 13; מֵאֵן *to refuse* Ex. 10, 3; מאס *to despise* Job 7, 16; מלא *to be full* Ps. 104, 24; צדק *to be just* Job 10, 15. 34, 5; קָטֹן *to be small* Gen. 32, 11; רבב *to be*[1] *many* Ps. 104, 24; שמח *to rejoice* 1 Sa. 2, 1; שָׂנֵא *to hate* Ps. 5, 6; add היה Gen. 42, 11. Isa. 15, 6; חפצתי Ps. 40, 9 etc.[2]

It will be understood, however, that many of these verbs are found also as aorists, i. e. with the emphasis not on the continuance of the state described, but on its commencement, or upon the fact of its existence generally at some period in the past; e. g. Gen. 28, 16 לא ידעתי *I knew* it not. 37, 3. 1 Sa. 10, 19. 22, 22. Ps. 39, 3 (p. 14). 41, 10. In itself the perfect enunciates simply the completion of an act: it is by way of accommodation to the usage of another language that, eliciting its special force from the context, we

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[1] 'To *become* many,' i. e. be multiplied, is רָבָה.

[2] Cf. *μέμαα, πέφυκα, πέποιθα, οἶδα, ἔρρωμαι,* etc. *We* commonly denote a state by the use of the present: the Greek, in verbs like these, 'conceives it as the result of the act necessary for attaining it, and therefore denotes it by the perfect.'

make the meaning more definite by exhibiting it explicitly, as occasion demands, under the form of an aorist, a perfect, or a present.

12. (6) It is used to express general truths known to have actually occurred, and so proved from experience: here again the idiomatic rendering in English is by means of the present[1]: Isa. 1, 3[a]. 40, 7. 8. 23. Ps. 7, 16 כָּרָה he *hath dug* or *diggeth* a pit and holloweth it out. 10, 3. 33, 13 f. 34, 11. 37, 23. 39, 12. 84, 4 מָצְאָה, שָׁחָה[2]. Pr. 22, 12. 13. Jer. 10, 13[b]. Qoh. 8, 14 (*has taken* place, or *takes* place). Comp. 1 Sa. 20, 2 Kt.

13. (7) The perfect is employed to indicate actions the accomplishment of which lies indeed in the future, but is regarded as dependent upon such an unalterable determination of the will that it may be spoken of as having actually taken place: thus a resolution, promise, or decree, especially a Divine one, is frequently announced in the perfect tense. A striking instance is afforded by Ruth 4, 3, where Bo'az, speaking of No'omi's determination to sell her land, says, מָכְרָה נָעֳמִי lit. *has sold* (has resolved to sell: the Engl. idiom would be *is selling*). Gen. 23, 11 *I give* thee the field; 13, Abraham replies, נָתַתִּי *I give* thee the value of the field (although the money does not actually pass till *v.* 16). 15, 18 to thy seed *I give* this land; similarly 1 Ki. 3, 13. Isa. 43, 14. Jer. 31, 33; Jud. 15, 3 נָקֹיתִי, referring to the contemplated

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[1] Though in particular cases a perfect may be used.

Both the pf. and aorist (the 'gnomic' aorist) are similarly used in Greek: Xen. Mem. 4, 2. 35 *πολλοὶ δὲ διὰ δόξαν καὶ πολιτικὴν δύναμιν μεγάλα κακὰ πεπόνθασιν* (preceded by three *presents*); cf. the aorist Plato Rep. 566 D. E. in the description of the conduct of the *τύραννος*, also Il. 9, 320. 13, 62. 243. 300. 14, 217. 18, 309 etc.

In the gnomic aorist (which is sometimes found coupled with the present, as Il. 17, 177 *ὅστε καὶ ἄλκιμον ἄνδρα φοβεῖ, καὶ ἀφείλετο νίκην* 'Ρηϊδίως) 'a fact of the past is exhibited as a rule for all time.'

[2] Not *may lay* (A.V.), which would be תשית: the word states a fact, exactly as מצאה does.

act of violence. 1 Sa. 15, 2. Ez. 21, 9 (cf. 8) הִכְרַתִּי. Lev. 26, 44 nevertheless, when they are in the land of their enemies, לֹא מְאַסְתִּים *I do not reject them.* Ps. 20, 7 now know I that Yahweh *is sure to save* his anointed. Nu. 32, 19 בָּאָה (*mil'el,* and so pf., not ptcp.[1]). 2 Chr. 12, 5 עזבתי.

Here also may be noticed the use of the pf. in Jer. 4, 13 Woe to us, for שֻׁדַּדְנוּ׃ *we are undone!* (at the prospect of the invader's approach: comp. ὄλωλα, and such phrases as Il. 15, 128 *μαινόμενε, φρένας ἠλέ,* **διέφθορας**). Isa. 6, 5. Ps. 31, 23. Lam. 3, 54. Nu. 17, 27.

14. (8) But the most special and remarkable use of the tense, though little more than an extension of the last idiom, is as the *prophetic perfect:* its abrupt appearance in this capacity imparts to descriptions of the future a forcible and expressive touch of reality, and reproduces vividly the certainty with which the occurrence of a yet future event is contemplated by the speaker[2]. Sometimes the perfect appears thus

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[1] It may be worth while here to remind the reader that in verbs ע״ו the pf. fem. בָּאָה is *mil'el,* the ptcp. fem. בָּאָה *milra'*; (הַשָּׁמָה, therefore, Isa. 51, 10, according to the punctuation, is the perfect, although preceded by the article; see, however, on this and similar passages, the writer's *Notes on the Hebrew Text of Samuel,* p. 58, or Ges.-Kautzsch, ed. 25, § 138, 3[b]). This distinction may be easily borne in mind, if it be recollected that in each case the position of the tone depends simply upon the particular application of a *general* rule: on the one hand, all *fem. adjectives* in ־ָה are regularly accented on the ultima, e.g. קְטֻנָּה; on the other hand, all *tense-forms* ending in ־ָה, ־ָ, ־ֶ, with a *vowel* (not *shwa'*) before the last radical, except in certain special cases, take the tone upon the penultima, e.g. הַגִּישׁוּ, קוּמִי, אֲשׁוּבָה, וְנָהֲרוּ. We are now further in a position to understand how upon exactly the same principle נֶאֱלָמָה Ps. 19, 8 must be the ptcp., and נֶאֱלָמָה Isa. 53, 7 the pausal form of the perfect.

[2] The Greek aorist is similarly used, at least in the apodosis, to 'express future events which must certainly happen' (Jelf, § 403, 2); and even coupled with a future, Il. 4, 161 *ἔκ τε καὶ ὀψὲ τελεῖ, σύν τε μεγάλῳ ἀπέτισαν.* 9, 413 (see further below, § 136 γ). Compare also its force in such descriptive passages as Il. 9, 7 (*ἔχεναν*). 15, 626. 16, 299–300. 20, 497. Phaedrus 245 A (*ἠφανίσθη*). 251 A. B. 254 B. etc.

only for a single word; sometimes, as though nothing more than an ordinary series of past historical events were being described, it extends over many verses in succession: continually the series of perfects is interspersed with the simple future forms, as the prophet shifts his point of view, at one moment contemplating the events he is describing from the *real standpoint* of the present, at another moment looking back upon them as accomplished and done, and so viewing them from an *ideal position* in the future.

It will be best to classify under distinct heads the various modes in which this perfect of certitude, or prophetic perfect, may appear.

(*a*) The description of the future scene may *begin* with the perfect, whether the verbs following (if there be any) fall back into the future or not: Nu. 24, 17 a star דָּרַךְ *hath proceeded* out of Jacob, and *shall* etc. Jud. 4, 14 hath he not gone out before thee? Isa. 5, 13 Therefore גָּלָה *hath* my people *gone* into captivity (although the captivity is only *anticipated*). 25 על כן חרה etc. 8, 23. 9, 1–6 the people that walked in darkness *have seen* a great light etc. 10, 28–31 (of the march of the Assyrian) he *is come* to 'Ayyâth etc. 21, 1 בא. 12 אתא. 24, 4–12 (except 9). 28, 2 הניח (the prophet sees Samaria already laid low on the ground). 30, 5. 33, 3. 42, 17. 45, 16f. 46, 1f. (the fall of Babylon and its idols spoken of as *achieved:* for the parallel ptcp. cf. Jer. 5, 6). Jer. 2, 26 הבישו. 5, 6 הִכָּם (where observe that the impf. and ptcp. follow: in each of the three parallel expressions the prophet seizes upon a fresh aspect of the scene). 13, 26 חשפתי. 28, 2 (in 4, the impf. אשבר). 32, 24 f. 46, 14–16. 23 f. 51, 8. 41. Ez. 3, 25. 24, 14^{b} etc. Amos 5, 2. Zeph. 3, 18. Ps. 22, 22. 30 all the fat ones of the earth *have eaten* and worshipped. 26, 12 my foot *standeth* in a level land. 30, 12. 36, 13 (the Psalmist sees the wicked already fallen). 41, 4. 71, 24. 15, 11 etc. Compare Jer. 6, 15^{b}. 49, 8. 50, 31 (עֵת פָּקַדְתִּיו).

It thus occurs (exceptionally) after oaths or other strong

asseverations; as אִם לֹא Jer. 15, 11 (22, 6 etc. with the impf.); כִּי אִם 2 Ki. 5, 20 (1 Sa. 26, 10. 2 Sa. 15, 21, the impf.; cf. § 115).

(β) It frequently appears after כִּי, the reason for an assertion or a command being found in some event the occurrence of which, though still future, is deemed *certain*, and contemplated accordingly by the writer; Isa. 11, 9 they will do no destruction in all my holy mountain, for the earth *is filled* with the knowledge of Yahweh (at the time alluded to *has been* filled). 15, 6b. 8. 9. 16, 8. 9 נפל. 23, 1. 4. 14 howl, for your stronghold *has been wasted!* 24, 18. 23 מלך. 29, 20. 32, 10 בלה. 14. 34, 2. 35, 6. 60, 1. Jer. 25, 14. 31, 6. 9b. 11. 25. Mic. 1, 9. 12. 16. Zeph. 1, 11. Zech. 11, 2. Ps. 6. 9 f. שָׁמַע. 28, 6. 31, 22 (prob.). 56, 14. 59, 17[1]. Gen. 30, 13 I am in luck, for the daughters אִשְּׁרוּנִי *are sure to call* me lucky!

Without כי, Isa. 21, 2 השבתי. 14 (reason for 13). 33, 14. 34, 14b. 15b. 16b. 35, 2. Zeph. 2, 2 like chaff *hath* the day (the time of delay before לרת חק) *passed by!* 3, 14 f. Lam. 4, 22.

(γ) But the pf. is also found (without כי) where, in a description of the future, it is desired to give variety to the scene, or to confer particular emphasis upon individual isolated traits in it; it may in this case appear in the midst of a series of imperfects, either *ἀσυνδέτως*, or connected with what precedes by the copulative, *provided that the* ו *is separated*

[1] In some of the passages from the Psalms we may not perhaps feel assured that the perfects are to be understood in this sense, as representing the certainty and confidence felt by the writers as regards the events they anticipate. It is no doubt *possible* that they may simply describe past facts or former experiences (like 4, 2. 31, 6 etc.) which the writer desires to refer to: so, for example, 28, 6. 31, 22. 36, 13. But the 'perfect of certitude' is of such frequent and well-established occurrence, and at the same time so much more forcible and appropriate to the context than the more common-place 'perfect of experience,' that we need not scruple to interpret accordingly. Such sudden turns as those in 6, 9. 28, 6. 30, 12 are no less effective and emphatic than the abrupt introduction of a new and dissimilar key in a piece of music.

from the verb by one or more intervening words (if this be not the case, i. e. if the conjunction is *immediately* followed by the verb, the imperfect tense with וְ is of course employed: see below, § 82). For instance, without *waw:*—

Isa. 5, 28. 30 חשך. 8, 8. 13, 10b. 16, 10. 17, 11b (if נִר be a verb). 19, 6b. 7b. 24, 14b. 25, 8 בִּלַּע he hath swallowed up death for ever! (contrast 7 ובלע). 30, 19 עָנְךָ as soon as he heareth, he *hath answered* thee! 33, 5b *hath* filled, etc. 47, 9. 49, 17. 51, 11b יַשִּׂיגוּן נָסוֹ[1]. Jer. 25, 38. 31, 5b. 47, 3. Joel 2, 10. 4, 15. Zech. 9, 15 הָמוּ. Ps. 37, 20. Job 5, 19 f. in six troubles he will deliver thee, and in seven evil will not touch thee; in famine פָּדָךְ *he hath redeemed* thee from death, and in war from the power of the sword!

Obs. After an imperative,—the poet, by an abrupt transition, picturing what he desires as already achieved, Isa. 21, 14. Ps. 68, 31b (cf. 29a). Many commentators, to be sure, prefer to punctuate the verbs in question as imperatives; but the alteration has a weakening effect, and does not appear to be necessary: cf. Ezek. 24, 5b.

With *waw:*—

Isa. 5, 27b (a particular feature in their approach described as though *present to the eye*). 11, 8 הָדָה . . . וְ. 18, 5 הַסִּיר הַתְּוֹ. 19, 8b. 25, 12. 30, 32. Jer. 48, 33b. Job 5, 23. 22, 28b. And similarly in descriptions of the present, Ps. 7, 13 (we see the bow *already drawn*). 11, 2 בוננו. Job 41, 20. Compare also Ps. 38, 17; Job 5, 11. 28, 25 and he *regulateth:* in all these passages there is a change of construction, the writer passing suddenly from an expression of *modality* to the statement of *a fact*[2].

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[1] In the parallel passage 35, 10 we have the smoother, less forcible ישיגו ונסו: the change is curious and instructive; it appears to have arisen from the tail of the ן becoming accidentally shortened, or a copyist in doubt preferring the more ordinary construction, as the LXX in 35, 10 as well as 51, 11 have ἀπέδρα (which they are unlikely to have gone out of their way to choose, had they read ונסו).

[2] I have been led to give a large number of examples of this use of the

15. Sometimes the perfect is used in order to give emphatic expression to a predicate, conceived as being immediately and necessarily involved in the subject of the verb[1]: thus Pr. 8, 35 Qri, he that finds me *has* (in that very act) *found* life. 14, 31. 16, 26. 30. 17, 5. 27, 16; cf. 22, 9.

16. (9) The perfect is used where we should employ by preference the pluperfect, i. e. in cases where it is desired to bring two actions in the past into a special relation with each other, and to indicate that the action described by the pluperfect was completed before the other took place. The function of the pluperfect is thus to throw two events into their proper perspective as regards each other: but the tense is to some extent a superfluous one—it is an elegance for which Hebrew possesses no distinct form, and which even in Greek, as is well known, both classical and Hellenistic, is constantly replaced by the simple aorist. Gen. 2, 2 God blessed the works which עשה *he had made*, LXX ἃ ἐποίησε; 6, 1. 19, 28 and behold the smoke עלה *had ascended* (had begun to ascend before Abraham looked). 20, 18 for *he had shut* up etc. 28, 11 בא. 31, 34 and Rachel *had* taken (before Laban entered into the tent, *v.* 33). 34, 5. 38, 15. Dt. 9, 16. Jud. 6, 28. 1 Sa. 28, 20 for לא אכל he *had* not *eaten* bread. 30, 12. 2 Sa. 18, 18. 1 Ki. 1, 6. 41 (they *had finished* eating when they heard). 2 Ki. 9, 16. Isa. 6, 6; after a conjunction like כַּאֲשֶׁר Gen. 7, 9. 18, 33. 20, 13 etc.

Or, somewhat differently, when it may be wished to indicate explicitly that a given action was anterior to another action named immediately afterwards (not, as in the first case, named previously), Ps. 30, 7. 8 (where by rendering אמרתי, העמדתה by the plupf. we bring them into distinct relief as *anterior* to the following הסתרת). 31, 23. Job 32, 4

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perfect, not only on account of its intrinsic importance, but also for a reason which will appear more fully in Chap. VIII.

[1] Cf. Rom. 13, 8 ὁ γὰρ ἀγαπῶν τὸν ἕτερον, τὸν νόμον πεπλήρωκε, and Winer, § 40. 4[b].

but Elihu *had waited*, for they were older than he. 42, 5 by hearing of the ear *had I heard* of thee, but now hath mine eye seen thee.

17. (10) Similarly, in the description of future events, it is often convenient in English to exhibit more distinctly the relation of two actions to one another by substituting for the Heb. perfect the future perfect, or 'paullo-post-futurum;' but this is by no means always obligatory, or even desirable. Thus after כי=*for:* Lev. 14, 48 נרפא. 19, 8 they that eat it shall bear their own sin, for (if any one eats it) he *will have profaned* what is holy to Yahweh. 1 Sa. 14, 10. 20, 22 if I say thus, go; for שִׁלְּחֶךָ Yahweh *will* (in that case) *have sent* thee away. 2 Sa. 5, 24 כי אז (אז omitted in 1 Chr. 14, 15). Ez. 3, 21 for (in that case) נְזָהָר (pf. *in pausa*) he *will have been warned* and THOU *wilt have delivered* thy soul; in a relative clause, Gen. 48, 6 which thou *shalt have* begotten (not *mayest* beget, which would be תּוֹלִיד). 1 Sa. 1, 28 all the days אשר היה *which he shall have been*. Jer. 8, 3 הַנִּדָּחִתִּים (24, 9 אֲדִיחֵם); after conjunctions, such as אַחַר Lev. 14, 43 אַחַר חָלַץ after that *he has taken away* the stones. 25, 48; עַד 2 Ki. 7, 3 עַד מֻתֵּנוּ: till we *are dead*. Ez. 34, 21. Mic. 5, 2 עַד עֵת יוֹלֵדָה יָלָדָה until the time when she that beareth *shall have* borne; עַד אֲשֶׁר אִם Gen. 28, 15 until *I have done* etc. Nu. 32, 17. Isa. 6, 11†; עַד אִם 30, 17. Gen. 24, 19. Ruth 2, 21†; כִּי אִם אמרתי לך 2 Ki. 4, 24 except I bid thee; כִּי Isa. 16, 12 it shall come to pass, כִּי נִרְאָה when Moab *has appeared* (cum apparuerit) etc. Ps. 138, 4. 1 Chr. 17, 11 when thy days מלאו *have been* fulfilled (in 2 Sa. 11, 12 ימלאו). Dan. 11, 36; אִם (=when), Isa. 4, 4: cf. § 138.

18. (11) The use of the perfect in both the protasis and apodosis of certain forms of hypothetical propositions will be illustrated below: see Chap. X. A few cases, however, may be noticed here in which the pf. is employed to denote events appertaining to past time, which *might have happened* but *did not happen*, which are therefore only for the moment conceived

as having occurred, under conditions not actually realized. In Greek the existence of such conditions is (though not universally[1], Jelf, §§ 858 f. Winer, § 42. 2[b]) noted by ἄν in the apodosis: we observe therefore that the Heb. perfect corresponds not merely to the Greek aorist by itself, but to the Greek aorist with ἄν, that in other words it expresses the *contingent* as well as the *actual* occurrence of an event—the sense of the reader, or the tone in which the words are spoken, readily determining to which category the event is to be referred. So after בְּמִעַט Ps. 73, 2. 119, 87. Pr. 5, 14; כַּאֲשֶׁר Zech. 10, 6[b]. Job 10, 19 I ought to have been (§ 39 β) as though לֹא הייתי I *had not been* born. Ob. 16 והיו כלוא היו. See further §§ 139, 141, 144.

19. (12) The perfect is used rather singularly in *questions:* 1. after עַד מָתַי Ex. 10, 3 until when מֵאַנְתָּ *wilt* thou *have* refused? Ps. 80, 5; or עַד אָנָה Ex. 16, 28, and with an impf. in the parallel clause Hab. 1, 2. Pr. 1, 22. Cf. Jer. 22, 23 מַה־נֵּחַנְתְּ (contrast 4, 30. 13, 21).

And 2. to express astonishment at what appears to the speaker in the highest degree improbable:—

Gen. 18, 12 הָיְתָה. Jud. 9, 9. 11. 13 *am I to have* lost my fatness וְהִלְכְתִּי and go? etc. 2 Ki. 20, 9 הֲלָךְ *iveritne*[2]*?* Nu. 17, 28 shall we ever have finished dying? Pr. 24, 28; and possibly Ps. 73, 11. Job 22, 13.

Gen. 21, 7 who[3] *could have* said to Abraham? Nu. 23, 10. 1 Sa. 26, 9 וְנָקָה . . . מִי שָׁלַח who *is to have* put forth his hand . . . and be guiltless? LXX τὶς ἐποίσει (quite different from

[1] And compare the use of the indicative in Latin, e. g. Hor. Carm. 2. 17, 27 Me truncus illapsus cerebro *Sustulerat* nisi Faunus ictum Dextra levasset.

[2] Where, accordingly, there is no occasion (with Hitzig on Ps. 11, 3) to change the punctuation and read הָלַךְ.

[3] Cf. Ephrem Syrus III. p. 59 if painters cannot paint the wind ܟܡܐ ܠܐ ܡܨܝ ܙܘܥܐ whose tongue *can have* described the Son of God? for which in str. 18 we have the impf. ܢܨܝ.

Dt. 5, 23. Lam. 3, 37. Pr. 30, 4. Job 9, 4 who ever hardened himself against him וַיִּשְׁלָם׃ and escaped whole? as is clear from both the sense of the passage and the difference in the *tense* of the second verb: see above, § 9, and Chap. VIII). Ps. 11, 3. 60, 11.

20. (13) Is there a *precative* perfect in Hebrew? or does the perfect in Hebrew, as in certain cases in Arabic, serve to give emphatic enunciation to a wish? The affirmative was maintained by Ewald, § 223^{b}, who cited Isa. 26, 15. Ps. 10, 16. 31, 6. 57, 7. 116, 16. Job 21, 16. 22, 18. Lam. 1, 21. 3, 57–61 and the 'old form of speech' preserved Ps. 18, 47; and by Böttcher, §§ 939^{g}, 947^{g}, who, accepting out of Ewald's instances only Ps. 116, 16. Job 21, 16. 22, 18. Lam. 3, 57–61, added to the list Isa. 43, 9. Mic. 1, 10 Kt. Ps. 4, 2. 7, 7. 22, 22. 71, 3. 141, 6 f.[1] In any case, if the usage exists, it is but an extension of the same manner of speech which has been already explained, § 14, viz. the perfect of certitude; the prominent position of the verb—in Arabic[2], to avoid misconstruction, it all but universally stands first in the sentence —aided by the tone of voice with which it is uttered, being sufficient to invest the conviction or hope, which is all that the tense employed in itself expresses, with the character of a wish. But the fact is that the evidence for this signification of the pf. is so precarious, the passages adduced in proof of it[3]

[1] Two other passages quoted, Jer. 50, 5. Joel 4, 11, do not belong here, the verb in each being attached to וְ.

[2] For the Arabic usage see Ewald, *Gramm. Arab.* §§ 198, 710; Wright, *Arabic Gramm.* ii. p. 3. Even the fact that in Hebrew the position of the verb is neglected ought to excite suspicion: in Arabic it is just the position which gives to the tense that interjectional force, upon which, in Ewald's words, its peculiar significance entirely depends.

[3] E. g. Ps. 4, 2. 116, 16 are quite naturally explained by § 9; 7, 7. 71, 3 resemble substantially ראיתה Ps. 10, 14. 35, 22; Lam. 3, 57 ff. has been discussed already; Isa. 26, 15 are words spoken from the standpoint of the future, and 43, 9 the tenses, if נקבצו be a perf. (so König, *Lehrgebäude*, i. p. 184), are similar to those in 41, 5 (Ew. Hitz. Del. Dillm. and Ges.-K. § 51 Rem. 3 [doubtfully], however, treat נקבצו as

admitting of a ready explanation by other means, that it will be safer to reject it altogether[1].

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an imperative). As regards Ps. 22, 22 it is to be noticed that the words in question stand on the border-ground between the petition for help and the thanksgiving for its approach: it might almost be said that the poet began with the intention of saying: ומקרני רמים תַּעֲנֵנִי, but that, as he wrote, the prospect of the deliverance burst upon him so brightly as to lead him to speak of it as an accomplished fact עניתני, which he then makes the key-note of the following verses 23–32. Compare further Hupfeld's note on Ps. 4, 2. Delitzsch would confine the use to such 'interjectional exclamations' as the one contained in the two verses from Job; but even there it is questionable whether it is necessary or legitimate to have recourse to it: Hitzig sees in רחקה only an earnest protestation of innocence, and translates by the present indicative.

[1] The same conclusion is defended, with additional reasons, by Prof. August Müller, in his review of the present work, pp. 202 f. (the precative perfect not used at all in Arabic to express concrete, personal petitions, such as would be contained in most of the passages referred to: in the other passages, no exegetical necessity for having recourse to it): it is adopted also by Ges.-Kautzsch, § 106. 3[b] *note*.